

Chloasma This describes the increased pigmentation of the cheeks, nose, and chin that affects around 50–70 percent of pregnant women. Using a protective sunscreen and avoiding the use of any photosensitizing skin-care products may reduce chloasma. A recent study found that using a highly protective sunscreen (SPF 50 and UVA-PF 28) prevented most pregnant women from developing chloasma.

Hair and nails

Hair stays longer in the growth phase during pregnancy, meaning that your scalp hair is likely to grow and thicken. Not so welcome is the fact that facial and body hair may also increase. After the birth, many women find that they suddenly lose a lot of hair as the growth phase stops. You should find that your hair is back to normal within six months.

Fingernails may also change, often becoming stronger, although some find that they become softer and brittle. Nails may develop white spots or transverse grooves, but these are rarely anything to worry about and don't mean that you're lacking in vitamins.

Teeth

Pregnant women are more prone to tooth decay (dental caries), bleeding gums, and chronic gum infection (periodontal disease). Poor dental health not only affects you but can also have an impact on your baby. Studies have linked infection of the gums in pregnant women to premature birth, and if a woman has ongoing tooth decay after the birth, her baby may acquire bacteria directly from her saliva, leading to tooth decay in the child later on. It's therefore important that you take care of your teeth during pregnancy and visit your dentist and dental hygienist regularly.

To keep your mouth healthy during pregnancy, brush twice a day with fluoride toothpaste and floss every day. Routine dental treatment and some local anesthetics are safe in pregnancy, although it's better to postpone elective dental treatments until after pregnancy or take care of them before pregnancy. Many women worry about having their teeth X-rayed in pregnancy. The radiation exposure from dental X-rays is minimal and the risk to your baby probably negligible. However, dentists will take every precaution to minimize your radiation exposure, covering you with a leaded apron before the X-rays.

ASK AN EXPERT

I am 18 weeks' pregnant and due to go on a beach vacation. I have become uncomfortable with my facial and body hair. How can I safely remove it?

You can safely tweeze, wax, and shave new stray hair. Skin bleaching and hair removal creams are probably safe during pregnancy, but there has been insufficient research to clear them since they can be absorbed through the skin and their effects on the baby are unknown. Permanent hair-removal techniques, such as laser and electrolysis, are thought to be safe in pregnancy. Both techniques penetrate the skin no deeper than a few millimeters. Consult your doctor to see if this is okay.

I've been using topical cream to treat acne and I've just found out that I'm pregnant. Will it harm my baby?

Tretinoin belongs to a group of medications called retinoids that contain vitamin A and may be associated with birth defects. Studies have looked at the effects of this cream in pregnancy and have found that babies whose mothers used it, even in the first trimester, had no increase in birth defects. However doctors recommend avoiding tretinoin cream in pregnancy. Another similar